Acknowledgements

In all the bars, in all the world, we were in Al Forsan, Abu Dhabi, unwinding after a three-session, nine-hour, series of interviews for this book. Alastair empathized with the unobtrusive pianist in the corner, playing to general indifference. ‘You’ve got to be really good to do that,’ he said.

My eye was taken by an aspiring county cricketer from another team, hovering on the edge of the group. He picked his moment, introduced himself with as much confidence as he could project, and asked if Alastair could spare some time to go over his game. It was readily given.

The notion of respect is exaggerated in professional sport, but here it was in its most pure form, as an interaction between generations. It is in Alastair’s nature to play down such an exchange, but it struck me as being as significant as any trawl through *Wisden* , as a measure of stature.

Like many top sportsmen, he is a fiercely driven individual who has an instinctive understanding of the importance of a team. In that context, it is appropriate to thank those who have helped us put together this book.

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Cookie is immersed in farm life. The work is constant, dictated by the seasons and a duty of care. He admits it doesn’t fit easily with the discipline